FREE GUIDE · AI AGENTS 101

How to automate your manual work with AI agents

A practical guide for business owners: what to automate, how to build your first agent, and how to run it without technical headaches.



Invoice processing · Social media content · Lead research · Appointment follow-ups · CRM data entry · Support replies · Proposal drafts · Review requests

PATH 01 · DIY

Build it yourself with Claude

Set up a project, add instructions, connect your tools. Powerful, with real limits worth knowing.

PATH 02 · DONE FOR YOU

Let Talk to me Data build it

Describe the work in plain English. We build, host and run the agent. No setup, no usage limits to manage.

The work that doesn't need a person is still done by a person.

Every business has a stack of recurring tasks that are well defined, predictable and repetitive. You could write the steps down once and hand them over for good. That's what an AI agent does, except it never clocks off, never forgets a step and never gets distracted. Here's what that looks like.

Invoice processing and bookkeeping

Vendor invoices arrive by email, get downloaded, and the numbers get typed into accounting software by hand. Line items, totals, categories: every field, every time.

MANUAL	20–40 min per invoice
AGENT	**Reads, categorizes and posts it automatically**

Social media content

Turning a blog post, product update or weekly insight into 5 platform-specific posts takes a chunk of every week, and it's the same formula each time.

MANUAL	2–3 hours a week
AGENT	**Drafts, formats and schedules for each platform**

Lead research at scale

Finding the right companies, pulling contact info, checking LinkedIn and writing a personal first line, one prospect at a time, for hours, before a single email goes out.

MANUAL	10–15 min per lead
AGENT	**Researches and enriches hundreds overnight**

Follow-ups and outreach

Leads who showed interest but didn't convert go quiet because nobody had time to follow up. Proposals go out, and then nothing.

MANUAL	Inconsistent or forgotten
AGENT	**Timed, personal sequences that always go out**

CRM and data entry

After every call or email, someone has to update the CRM: status, notes, next steps. It's always the last thing done, and often it isn't.

MANUAL	5–10 min per contact
AGENT	**Logs and updates in real time**

Reviews and re-engagement

Happy customers rarely leave a review unless someone asks at the right moment. Past customers go quiet because there's no regular reason to reach out.

MANUAL	Hit-or-miss timing
AGENT	**Sent at the right moment, every time**

Manual times are typical estimates. Your numbers will vary.

CLAUDE · PROJECT SETUP

You can build your first agent in Claude today. Here's how.

Claude lets you create projects that keep your instructions and files in one place, and connect to real tools through connectors (built on MCP, the Model Context Protocol). Here's the setup that gets an agent running.

1

Create a new project

Open Projects in Claude and create one. Name it after the workflow, like "Invoice Processor" or "Lead Research Agent". The project holds the instructions and context for this one agent.

2

Add your instructions and knowledge

Add project instructions and upload any reference files. Be specific: describe the task, the output format, the rules the agent must follow, and examples of what good looks like.

EXAMPLE INSTRUCTIONS FOR A SOCIAL CONTENT AGENT

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"You are a social media assistant for [Business Name]. When given a topic or URL, create: (1) a LinkedIn post of 150-200 words with a hook and 3 bullet points, (2) a 5-post thread for X, (3) an Instagram caption with 5 relevant hashtags. Always write in first person, professional but conversational."
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3

Connect your tools with connectors

Go to Customize, then Connectors, click + and turn on the tools your workflow needs, such as Google Drive, Gmail or Notion. Once connected, Claude can read from, write to and take actions in those apps.

4

Start a chat in the project and run it

Open the project and start a new chat. Claude follows your project instructions automatically. Give it a trigger, like "Process the invoices in the /Invoices/Pending folder", and it works through the task with the connected tools.

TOOLS PEOPLE CONNECT

Gmail · Google Drive · Notion · Airtable · QuickBooks · Slack · HubSpot · Calendly · and many more

EXAMPLE AGENT · CONTENT RESEARCH

The system prompt behind our Content Research Agent

This is the exact prompt we use to find breakout AI topics for our daily short-form videos. Paste it into a Claude project's instructions to try it, or run it on Talk to me Data with no setup.

ROLE

You are my AI content research agent. I'm the founder of Talk to me Data, a platform where businesses build, deploy and host AI agents. I create short-form video content daily about AI. Your job is to find breakout AI topics before they peak, so I can post about them early.

WHAT COUNTS AS "BREAKOUT"

A topic is breakout when it shows at least two of these:

- Sudden spike in discussion across X, Reddit, Hacker News, YouTube, or LinkedIn in the last 24-72 hours
- A major launch, release, or announcement (models, agents, tools, funding, regulation)
- Multiple credible outlets or creators covering it within a short window
- A clear "this changes things for people/businesses" angle
- Not yet saturated: most short-form creators haven't covered it

HOW TO WORK

1. Always use web search. Never rely on memory for what's current. Today's date matters, so check the date on every source.
2. Run several searches across different angles: new model/tool launches, AI agents news, big-company announcements, open-source releases, regulation, viral demos, and what's trending on Hacker News, Reddit (r/singularity, r/LocalLLaMA, r/artificial), and X.
3. Prioritize sources from the last 72 hours. Flag anything older.
4. Verify before reporting. If a claim appears in only one low-quality source, mark it as "unconfirmed."
5. Never invent stats, quotes, or links. If you can't find something, say so.

OUTPUT FORMAT (keep it scannable)

Give me the top 5 breakout topics, ranked. For each one:

`**[Rank]. Topic title**`

- What happened: 1-2 sentences
- Why it's breaking out: the signal (spike, launch, coverage)
- Saturation: Low / Medium / High (how many creators already covered it)
- Content angle: one hook idea for a 30-60 second video
- Business angle: how it connects to AI agents or business automation (only if it genuinely fits)
- Sources: links with publish dates

End with:

- "Watchlist": 3 emerging topics not breaking out yet but worth monitoring
- "Skip": any hyped topic that's overblown or already saturated, with a one-line reason

RULES

- Be concise. No filler, no long intros.
- Keep a neutral, factual tone in the research. Save the hooks for the content angle section.
- If I ask for a specific niche (e.g. "agents only" or "open-source only"), narrow the search to that.
- If my request is unclear, ask one short question before searching.
- If I say "go deeper" on a topic, research it further and give me: a timeline, key players, counterarguments, and 3 hook options.
- Don't repeat topics from earlier in this project unless there's a significant update. Tell me what's new.

DEFAULT COMMAND

When I say "Run today's scan," do the full process above and give me the top 5 plus watchlist and skip list.

Use this agent on Talk to me Data →

Free to start · No code · You stay in control
app.talktomedata.com/signup

EXAMPLE AGENT · LEAD GENERATION

A system prompt for a Leads Generator Agent

This prompt finds businesses showing clear signs they need an agent, and drafts a first line for each. Use it as a starting point, or have us build a custom version around your market and tools.

ROLE

You are my AI lead research agent. I'm the founder of Talk to me Data, a platform where businesses build, deploy and host AI agents. Your job is to find small and mid-sized businesses that would clearly benefit from an AI agent right now, so I can reach out with something useful.

WHAT COUNTS AS A "HOT" LEAD

A business is a hot lead when it shows at least two of these:

- Signs of repetitive manual work: slow replies, phone-only booking, manual quote requests, no online scheduling
- Hiring in the last 30 days for work an agent could support (reception, admin, customer support, data entry, social media)
- Growth signals: a new location, funding, a product launch, or a fast-rising number of reviews
- Public reviews mentioning slow responses, missed calls, or no follow-up
- Uses tools an agent can connect to (e.g. Gmail, HubSpot, QuickBooks, Calendly)

HOW TO WORK

1. Always use web search. Never rely on memory for company details, and check the date on every source.
2. Search from several angles: job boards, Google Maps and review sites, company websites, LinkedIn company pages, local news, and funding announcements.
3. Stick to the niche and region I give you. If I don't give one, ask.
4. Verify before reporting. If a signal appears in only one weak source, mark it as "unconfirmed."
5. Never invent names, emails, phone numbers, stats, or quotes. Only list contact details the business publishes itself, never personal ones. If you can't find something, say so.

OUTPUT FORMAT (keep it scannable)

Give me the top 10 leads, ranked by fit. For each one:

[Rank]. Company name

- Who they are: 1 sentence (industry, size, location)
- Why now: the signals you found
- Manual-work pain: the specific task an agent could take off their plate
- Agent idea: one agent that fits (lead qualification, booking, support, invoicing)
- Fit: High / Medium / Low, with a one-line reason
- Public contact: website and published business email or contact page
- Sources: links with publish dates

End with:

- "Openers": a short, personal first line for the top 3 leads, based only on what you found
- "Skip": any business that looked promising but isn't a fit, with a one-line reason

RULES

- Be concise. No filler, no long intros.
- Keep the research neutral and factual. Save the persuasion for the openers.
- Openers are plain English: no hype, no fake familiarity, no invented compliments.
- If my request is unclear, ask one short question before searching.
- If I say "go deeper" on a lead, give me: a company snapshot, the likely decision-maker role, the tools they seem to use, and 3 opener options.
- Don't repeat leads from earlier in this project unless something has changed. Tell me what's new.

DEFAULT COMMAND

When I say "Run today's lead scan for [niche] in [city or region]," do the full process above and give me the top 10 plus openers and skip list.

Request a Custom Agent from Talk to me Data →

Built around your niche and tools · No code
app.talktomedata.com/signup

SEE IT IN ACTION

Watch: how to build an AI agent from scratch

Learn how to build an AI agent from zero with Claude, and how Talk to me Data can build and run one for you.



Watch on YouTube →

youtu.be/VQS9hS9PCdU

REALITY CHECK

The DIY path works, until it doesn't.

Claude Projects are powerful. But if you've run a long agent workflow inside Claude, you've probably hit the same walls. They aren't bugs. They come from how chat-based AI plans are built.

USAGE LIMITS

Claude's paid plans have a five-hour session limit and a weekly limit. A long agent workflow, like processing 50 invoices, researching 200 leads or writing a week of content, can use up a session in one go. When that happens, the work pauses until the limit resets or you buy extra usage.

Agents stall mid-task

When the limit hits, the workflow stops wherever it is. Partial results, half-done batches and uneven outputs are left for you to pick up.

Your agent shares your limit

The usage that runs your agent is the same usage you'd spend drafting an email or answering a question. A heavy agent run leaves less for everything else.

API keys and infrastructure

Running agents reliably outside the chat means managing API keys, rate limits, hosting, error handling and monitoring. That's a part-time job in itself.

ILLUSTRATION · ONE SESSION, INVOICE-PROCESSING AGENT (100 INVOICES)



Session start · ~35 invoices done · ~70 invoices done · **Limit reached, agent pauses**

Illustrative example. Real numbers depend on your plan and the task.

The root issue: chat apps are built for conversation: quick questions, creative tasks, back-and-forth. Agents that run in the background, at scale and without supervision, need a different setup.

TALK TO ME DATA

Describe the work in plain English. We build and run the agent.

You shouldn't need to understand API keys, usage limits, connector setup or cloud hosting to automate your business. Talk to me Data handles all of it. You get the output of a running agent without building or maintaining one.

WHAT YOU NEED	DIY WITH CLAUDE	TALK TO ME DATA
No usage limits to manage	× Session and weekly limits apply	✓ **Runs on our infrastructure**
Runs around the clock	× Only while you're running it	✓ **Always on, fully hosted**
No setup	× Projects, connectors and instructions	✓ **Describe it, we build it**
Your Claude stays free for you	× The agent uses your plan's usage	✓ **Separate, so use Claude freely**
No API keys to manage	× Needed to run outside the chat	✓ **Fully managed**
Monitoring and updates	× Your responsibility	✓ **Included**

01 · YOU SIGN UP

Sign up free

Create your account. Free to start, no code.

02 · YOU DESCRIBE

Tell us the job

Describe the manual task in plain English. No specs, no technical requirements. Just how you do it today.

03 · IT RUNS

Your agent goes live

We build it, connect your tools, test it and host it. You approve what it does and can change it any time.

100% CUSTOM · BUILT AROUND YOUR WORKFLOW

We don't sell templates. Every agent is built for your business.

Whether you use QuickBooks, HubSpot, Gmail, Notion or your own internal tool, we map your steps, your rules and your tools into an agent that works the way you do.

Pick the task you'd love to never do by hand again.

Sign up free, tell us about one task, and we'll build a custom agent for it, connected to the tools you already use.

EXAMPLES OF CUSTOM AGENTS WE'VE BUILT

- ✓ Vendor invoices → line items posted to QuickBooks or Xero
- ✓ One blog post → 5 platform-specific posts, scheduled and published
- ✓ A prospect list → enriched with emails, LinkedIn info and a personal opener
- ✓ A missed call → instant SMS reply and a booked follow-up, no human needed
- ✓ A completed job → review request, CRM update and invoice, all automatic



Get Started →

Free to start · No code · You stay in control · app.talktomedata.com/signup